



Setting Appointments

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 10 of 18 · Getting the Load · about a 14-minute read

You booked the furniture load, you negotiated a rate you're proud of, and you sent Marcus to Atlanta to pick it up. He rolls in at eight in the morning, ready to load — and there are six trucks ahead of him, because this shipper loads first-come, first-served. He doesn't get loaded until one in the afternoon. Five hours, gone: five hours off his clock, five hours that shove his delivery later, five hours he sat for free.

Or flip it to the other end. Marcus runs hard and gets to Dallas a day early — but nobody confirmed when the receiver could actually take the load, and they can't unload him until two days from now. So the truck just... sits.

A perfectly booked, perfectly priced load is quietly bleeding time and money at the dock. And that's not the driver's fault, and it's not bad luck — it's a coordination job that belongs to you, with a name nobody warns you about: setting the appointments. Do it well and the truck flows; do it badly and the best rate you ever negotiated leaks away an hour at a time.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Lock down both ends of a load — pickup and delivery — with times that actually work: you'll know the difference between a facility that runs on appointments and one that's first-come, first-served, you'll coordinate the right times with the shipper and the receiver, you'll build those times around what your driver can realistically run, and you'll protect his clock so a long wait at the dock turns into detention pay instead of a silent loss.

1 The Appointment Is the Bridge

Booking a load told you *what* you're hauling and *how much* it pays. The appointment tells you the last missing piece — *exactly when* — and it's what turns a booked load into a real schedule your driver can run. Here's the rule to hold onto: a load isn't truly ready to roll until *both* ends have confirmed times. You need to know when the shipper will load it and when the receiver will take it, because those two times define the entire timeline in between.

And this is squarely your job. The driver drives; the broker connects you to the load; but making sure there are real, workable times on both ends — and that they fit together — is pure coordination, and that's the dispatcher's lane. It's not glamorous, but it's the difference between a truck that keeps moving and a truck that sits.

2 Two Ways a Facility Handles Arrivals

Every shipper and receiver handles incoming trucks one of two ways, and you need to know which *before* the truck rolls, because it completely changes how you plan.

The first is an **appointment**. The facility works to specific scheduled times — "deliver Thursday at 10 a.m." You either request a time or they assign one, and the truck is expected then. Most larger, organized facilities — especially receivers like distribution centers and grocery warehouses — run on appointments. With an appointment, your whole job is to build the driver's schedule so he *hits that time*: not so early he's sitting for hours, not late.

The second is **FCFS** — first come, first served. There's no set time. The facility loads or unloads trucks in the order they show up, during their operating hours. Show up to an empty dock and you're in and out; show up behind six trucks and you wait. With FCFS, the play is different: you aim to get your driver there *early*, near the start of their hours, to beat the line — and you warn him there could be a wait regardless.

By appointment A SCHEDULED TIME	FCFS — first come, first served NO SET TIME
HOW IT WORKS You request or are assigned a specific time ; the truck is expected then and worked in around that slot.	HOW IT WORKS Trucks are loaded or unloaded in arrival order , during the facility's operating hours.
WHO RUNS THIS WAY Most large, organized facilities — distribution centers, grocery warehouses, big receivers.	WHO RUNS THIS WAY Many shippers and smaller docks that just work trucks as they come.
YOUR PLAN Build the schedule to hit the time — not hours early, not late.	YOUR PLAN Get there early , near opening, to beat the line — and warn the driver a wait is still possible.

Same load, two completely different plans. So one of the first questions you settle on any load is simple: *appointment or first-come, at each end?* Get that answer before you ever tell the driver when to show up.

3 Setting the Times: Coordinate Both Ends

Now the actual work, and it's two conversations — one for each end of the load.

The pickup, with the shipper

Confirm when the freight will be *ready* and when the shipper can load: their hours, whether it's appointment or FCFS, and any check-in steps the driver needs — a gate, a shipping office, a **PO number** to give. Sometimes the broker relays all this; sometimes you call the shipper directly. Either way, you end up with a clear pickup plan.

The delivery, with the receiver

This is the one that matters most and that new dispatchers forget: you have to **coordinate the delivery appointment with the receiver**. Confirm their receiving hours, whether they take appointments or run FCFS, and — if it's appointments — book an actual delivery time your driver can realistically hit. Sometimes the broker sets the delivery appointment for you; sometimes you call the receiver and set it yourself. But it is *your* job to make sure there is a confirmed delivery time and that it's one the truck can actually make.

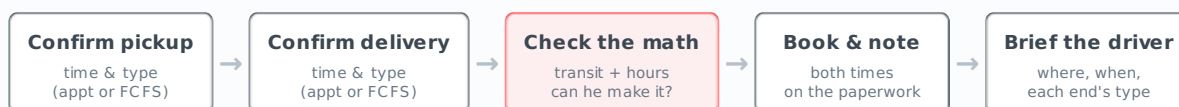
GET IT IN WRITING

Whatever you confirm, write it down and get it documented — the pickup and delivery times belong in your notes and on the load's paperwork (they typically land on the rate confirmation, which is its own lesson). A time that lives only in your memory isn't a time you can hold anyone to.

4 Build the Appointment Around What the Driver Can Run

Here's the mistake that turns appointment-setting into a disaster: agreeing to a time without checking whether your driver can *make* it. An appointment is a promise, and you already know how to tell whether a delivery promise is keepable — it's the transit-time and hours math from the feasibility lesson.

So before you lock a delivery appointment, run the quick check: how far is it, how many driving days at roughly five hundred miles a day, and given the pickup time and the driver's available hours, what's the earliest he can realistically be there — with a little buffer for traffic, weather, or a slow dock? If the appointment the receiver offers fits that, great — book it. If it's *earlier* than the driver can legally and physically arrive, you do not accept it — you negotiate the appointment: ask for a later slot, or adjust the pickup, *before* the truck rolls. Never commit your driver to an appointment he'd have to break his hours to reach. The appointment is exactly where that feasibility math stops being a calculation and becomes a schedule you're on the hook for.



The order matters: you settle the times first, then **check them against what the driver can run** before you commit to anything — because the appointment is the step where the feasibility math becomes a promise.

5 Protect the Clock at the Dock, and Brief the Driver

First, know *how* the freight changes hands, because it decides whether your driver waits at all. A **live load** — or **live unload** — means he stays with the trailer while it's loaded or unloaded; he's waiting, so the clock is everything. **Drop and hook** is the opposite: he drops one trailer and hooks a pre-loaded one and rolls, sometimes leaving a **drop trailer** for the facility to fill on its own time — fast, with little or no waiting. You'll usually know which a load is when you set it up, and it changes the plan: a drop is in-and-out, but a live load is where the clock — and detention — comes into play.

So for those live loads, once the driver arrives, the clock matters and you protect it. When he shows up for his appointment, the facility usually gets a window — commonly about **two hours of free time** — to get him loaded or unloaded. Stay inside that window and all's well. Hold him *past* it, and that's **detention** — money the facility or broker owes you for the wasted time, exactly like you saw in the load-board lesson. But here's the catch: you only ever collect detention if you *tracked the times* — when he arrived and when he was finally loaded or unloaded. So make sure those times get recorded; without them, you have no claim.

Free time
~ 2 HOURS, NO CHARGE

Detention
BILLABLE — IF YOU TRACKED IT

Driver arrives

~2 hrs

No recorded times, no claim. Note when he arrived and when he was loaded or unloaded — that record is the only thing that turns a long wait into money owed.

Two more clock realities. Be **on time**: a driver who's late for an appointment can get turned away or pushed to "whenever we get to you," burning hours and goodwill. And early helps on FCFS, where beating the line is the whole game.

Finally, close the loop with your driver. Once the appointments are set, he needs to know it all clearly: where and when to be at each end, whether it's an appointment or first-come, any check-in instructions, and the standing rule to call you the moment he's running behind. (Handing the driver the full dispatch details is its own lesson — but the appointment times are the heart of it.)

Walkthrough — Setting Both Ends of the Anchor Load

Booked: Atlanta → Dallas furniture, Tuesday pickup, ~1,000 mi, ~2 transit days. Watch the two ends get handled differently — on purpose.

PICKUP — ATLANTA SHIPPER		FCFS
TYPE	First come, first served. Receiving 7:00 AM - 3:00 PM .	
PLAN	Send Marcus to arrive ~7:00 AM Tuesday to beat the line — warn him there may still be a wait. Check in at the shipping office, give the PO number.	

DELIVERY — DALLAS RECEIVER		BY APPOINTMENT
CHECK	~1,000 mi ÷ ~500/day = ~2 driving days . Tue AM pickup → earliest realistic arrival ~Thursday . (Confirm against Marcus's hours.)	
OFFER	Receiver's first slot is Thursday 8:00 AM — tight (he'd have to stage near Dallas Wednesday night). Ask for a little later.	
BOOK	Thursday 1:00 PM , with buffer. Achievable. ✓ Note both times — they go on the rate confirmation.	

BRIEF MARCUS	
PICKUP	Atlanta, Tuesday, FCFS — be there at open (~7 AM), expect a possible wait.
DELIVERY	Dallas, Thursday 1:00 PM appointment.
TRACK	Arrival and loaded times at the shipper (detention if he's held past ~2 hrs).
RULE	Call me the moment anything slips.

Notice the two ends were handled differently on purpose: the pickup was first-come, so the plan was *get there early and expect a wait*; the delivery was an appointment, so the plan was *pick a time the truck can actually hit, with buffer*. And the delivery appointment wasn't just whatever the receiver offered first — it was checked against the transit math and nudged to a time Marcus can make. That's the whole skill: the right time on each end, built around what the driver can really run, and tracked at the dock so a wait pays you instead of costing you.

Module 10 Glossary — your quick reference

The scheduling words that decide whether a truck flows or sits.

How a facility takes trucks

Appointment A specific scheduled time a facility expects the truck — you request it or it's assigned. Build the driver's schedule to hit it.

FCFS (first come, first served) No set time — trucks are worked in arrival order during operating hours. Arrive early to beat the line.

How the freight changes hands

Live load / live unload The driver stays with the trailer while it's loaded or unloaded — he's waiting, so the clock (and detention) matters.

Drop and hook The driver drops one trailer and hooks a pre-loaded one and rolls — fast, little or no waiting.

Drop trailer A trailer left at a facility to be loaded or unloaded on its own time, picked up later — no driver waiting.

Protecting the clock

Free time The window (commonly ~2 hours) a facility has to load or unload before detention starts. (From the load-board lesson.)

Detention Money owed for holding the driver past free time — claimable only if you recorded the arrival and load/unload times. (From the load-board lesson.)

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. **What's the difference between an appointment facility and an FCFS facility, and how does each change your plan?**
2. **You've just booked a load. Whose times do you confirm, and what do you confirm with each?**
3. **The receiver's only delivery appointment is earlier than your transit math says the driver can arrive. What do you do?**
4. **What is free time, and why must you track the driver's arrival and load/unload times?**
5. **Once appointments are set, what does the driver need to know?**

ANSWERS

1. Appointment = a specific scheduled time; build the driver's schedule to hit it. FCFS = no set time, loaded or unloaded in arrival order within operating hours; aim to arrive early to beat the line and warn the driver of a possible wait.
2. Both ends — the shipper for pickup (ready time, hours, appointment vs FCFS, check-in) and the receiver for delivery (receiving hours, appointment vs FCFS, and a confirmed, achievable delivery time). Make sure a confirmed delivery time actually exists.
3. Don't accept an unachievable appointment — negotiate a later slot (or adjust the pickup), using the transit/HOS math. Never commit the driver to a time he'd have to break his hours to make.
4. Free time is the window (commonly ~2 hours) a facility has to load or unload before detention starts. You track arrival and completion times so you can claim detention for time held past free time — no recorded times, no claim.
5. Where and when to be at each end, whether each end is an appointment or FCFS, any check-in instructions, and to call you the moment he's running late.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 11: THE RATE CONFIRMATION & CARRIER PACKET

So your load is now booked, priced, and scheduled — real times locked on both ends. There's just one thing left before the wheels actually turn: getting all of it in writing. The rate confirmation is the document that makes the whole deal official — the rate, the dates, the times, the terms, all on one page — and the carrier packet is how you prove your trucking company to the broker so they'll release the load. Next, we handle the paperwork that turns a verbal deal into a real, protected one.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches appointment-setting as a generic skill. Your own operation adds its specifics — who sets appointments (the dispatcher or a scheduling desk) and any scheduling portals it uses with big receivers; its rule for how early to stage a driver on FCFS loads and the buffer it wants between the transit estimate and a booked appointment; how appointment times are logged in its system and put on the rate con; its detention-tracking procedure and how detention gets claimed; and who to escalate to when an appointment can't be made to fit the driver's hours. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*